

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

NOBLE SEAT
Devraj Singh at Jai Mahal Palace

ROYAL DISPUTE

AN UNEASY TRUCE

By Rohit Parihar

On December 15, 2021, a long-drawn-out legal battle between members of the erstwhile Jaipur royalty came to a close. The 15-year-old fight over the ownership of two prized properties—Jai Mahal Palace and Ram Bagh Palace—was finally resolved after the court appointed mediator, justice (retd) Joseph Kurian, brokered a settlement between Devraj Singh and Lalitya Kumari, grandchildren of the late Maharani Gayatri Devi of Jaipur, and their cousin Vijit Singh. As per the settlement, Devraj and Lalitya get ownership of Jai Mahal in lieu of selling their 4.4. per cent shares in Ram Bagh to Vijit. Both palaces, turned hotels, are managed by the Taj Hotels group.

The fight is the first—of at least half a dozen venomous legal disputes over as many prime properties once owned by the Jaipur royalty—to have reached resolution. "I am happy with what we have arrived at and hope that the legal battles that have been on among us do not carry on to the next generation," says Devraj, 40. So, while the hope is that this will set the ball rolling for other disputes to be resolved as well, given the bitterness among the four sons born to Sawai Man Singh, the king of Jaipur at the time of independence, from his three wives, it seems unlikely.

Diya Kumari, BJP MP and daughter of Bhawani Singh, the last maharaja of Jaipur, has said that her family intends to fight for its legitimate one-fourth share in Ram Bagh Palace. The politician may not take kindly to Devraj and Lalitya giving up their similar claim of one-fourth share in Ram Bagh to her rivals since it was her father who had helped the two reclaim their rights from Gayatri Devi, with whom the siblings were estranged.

The Jaipur royalty is embroiled in this feud despite Sawai Man Singh having worked out a division of property during his lifetime. Bhawani Singh, Man Singh's eldest son from his first wife, was named successor and gifted Raj Mahal Palace. The remaining three sons—Jai Singh, Prithvi Singh and Jagat Singh—were adopted as heads of various *thikanas* (estates) and were granted independent land holdings. However, the sudden abolition of privileges and privy purses of all princely rulers in 1971 under the 26th amendment act abruptly dethroned Bhawani Singh and gave his three stepbrothers an excuse to challenge their father's will. Diya Kumari is Bhawani Singh's only child and her son Padmanabh Singh, 23, currently represents Jaipur royalty.

Man Singh also converted the opulent Ram Bagh Palace into a hotel and bequeathed it to all his four sons equally in 1956-57. After his death in 1970, Bhawani Singh also got the City palace, Jaigarh Fort, Moti Doongri Fort, Ramgarh Lodge, Sawai Madhopur Lodge, Jaipur Palace at Mount Abu and a bungalow at Civil Lines besides